

Grapes

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ONE

Concord

A grape is a berry. This is not a figure of speech. It is a botanical classification, and, like many botanical classifications, it has the effect of making the ordinary seem improbable and the improbable seem ordinary.¹ Few things are entirely what they seem. The grape is a berry, and a strawberry is not, and anyone who has trouble with this distinction has not spent enough time around plants.

The skin of a grape is the exocarp. The flesh is the mesocarp. The thin layers around the seeds are the endocarp. The ovary has two compartments, each with two ovules, so a grape can have at most four seeds, and seeded cultivars have one to four. The waxy film on the outside of the skin is the bloom. It is the thing you see on a Concord grape that makes it look as though it has just come in from the cold. Wipe it off and the grape turns darker, shinier, more obvious, and less itself.

The grape belongs to the genus *Vitis*, in the family Vitaceae.²

¹A strawberry is not a berry. It is an accessory fruit: most of its flesh grows from the receptacle, the swollen tip of the stem, and the tiny specks on its surface, each one an achene, are the actual fruits. A raspberry is not a berry either. It is an aggregate fruit, a cluster of drupelets, each with its own seed, its own thin skin. The grape, by contrast, is the real thing: skin, flesh, and seeds, all from the ovary wall, no stone.

²The family has sixteen genera and about nine hundred and fifty species, if you

Vitis has sixty to eighty species, depending on whom you ask, and the reason no one can agree is that the Asian species are poorly defined, which is a polite way of saying that not enough botanists have gone to look at them. Most species are native to two places: eastern Asia and North America. A single species, *vinifera*, is European and West Asian, and it is the one that makes nearly all the wine in the world.

The wild ancestor of the cultivated grape is *Vitis vinifera* subspecies *sylvestris*, which has male and female plants. The cultivated vine has hermaphrodite flowers, which simplifies things considerably if you are a vine. Domestication happened in western Asia, about eight thousand years ago. A long time to have been at it, and still not to agree on how many varieties there are.

☞ The OIV—the International Organisation of Vine and Wine, which is based in Paris, where organisations of vine and wine tend to be based—speaks of ten thousand known grapevine varieties. The Vitis International Variety Catalogue lists twenty-one thousand and forty-five variety names, of which twelve thousand two hundred and fifty are *vinifera*, but many of these are synonyms, the same grape wearing different names in different countries.³ The true number of distinct *vinifera* varieties is estimated at about six thousand. Of these, thirteen cover more than a third of the world's vineyard area, and thirty-three cover half. The grape has been generous with its variations but stingy with its success.

In 2018 the world produced seventy-seven point eight million tonnes of grapes.⁴ Whether any given person actually received twenty-two pounds of grapes is another question. Distribution is not the

follow Wen, and twelve genera if you follow Britannica, and neither is wrong, exactly; they are counting different things in different ways, which is what taxonomists do.^a

³A grape that travels collects names, as any traveller does.

⁴Fifty-seven per cent became wine, must, or juice. Thirty-six per cent were table

^aVirginia creeper and Boston ivy belong to the same family. Most of its members climb.

same as division.

A bunch of grapes is botanically a panicle.⁵ I bought a bunch in January. They were red, seedless, from Chile, which is where American table grapes come from in the winter, because in the southern hemisphere it is summer, and a grape does not know what country it is in. The label said "Product of Chile." The bunch sat on my desk for three days before I counted it. I do not know why I counted it. I have been paid, for most of my life, to be careful, and counting is a form of care, or a form of habit, which may be the same thing.

The first count was a hundred and seventeen. I counted again and got a hundred and eighteen. I counted a third time, slowly, moving each berry aside with the tip of a pencil, and got a hundred and seventeen. The third count agreed with the first, which ought to have settled the matter, but it did not settle it entirely, because I do not know what I miscounted in the second pass, and a discrepancy, even a discrepancy of one, will stay in the mind the way a wrong note stays in the ear long after the orchestra has moved on.

The first grape I knew was not, strictly speaking, a grape. It was Welch's grape jelly, in a jar that became a glass. In the early nineteen-sixties, Welch's sold its jelly in tumblers printed with Flintstones characters, about four and a quarter inches tall, and when the jelly was gone the glass went into the cupboard and stayed there, because nobody in a small town in Iowa threw away a glass.⁶ I remember it on

grapes. Seven per cent were dried—and it takes roughly four kilograms of fresh grapes to make one kilogram of raisins, so the raisin is a kind of concentrate.^a

⁵Its stalk before the first branch is the peduncle, its main axis the rachis; each berry hangs on a pedicel. A cluster can carry as many as a thousand flowers; fruit set is considered good if about one flower in three becomes a berry.

⁶I do not remember which character was on mine. I remember the jelly.

^aThe largest producers, in millions of tonnes: China, 11.7; Italy, 8.6; the United States, 6.9; Spain, 6.9; France, 6.2. The world's population that year was 7.7 billion. Divide it out and you get about ten kilograms per person, or twenty-two pounds, roughly the weight of a small child's bicycle.

white bread with peanut butter, which is the combination that Americans call a peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwich, as though there were no other jelly and no other sandwich, which, in the rural Midwest in 1960, there more or less was not.

⁷ By the time I was eating it the substitution was so complete that the word “jelly,” unmodified, meant grape, the way the word “Coke,” in certain parts of the South, means any soft drink at all. We are loyal to the first few things we are given, and we call the loyalty taste.

The taste that Americans call “grape” is the taste of one variety.⁸ It is the taste of the Concord. The distance between a Concord and a Chardonnay is the distance between the New World and the Old, which is a geographical fact before it is anything else.

The Concord was made by a man named Ephraim Wales Bull, who was born in Boston on March 4, 1806, and who moved to Concord, Massachusetts, in August of 1836, to a house on Lexington Road that is now called Grapevine Cottage. In the autumn of 1843, by his own account, he sowed seeds from a wild grape, and by 1849 the selected vine bore good fruit. He exhibited it at the Massachusetts Horticultural Society in 1853. It was first sold by C. M. Hovey, of Boston, in 1854.

☛ The Concord is usually called a cultivar of *Vitis labrusca*, but it

⁷The first published recipe for the sandwich appeared in 1901, in the *Boston Cooking-School Magazine*, by Julia Davis Chandler, and the jelly it called for was currant or crab-apple, not grape. Grape came later.^a

⁸The compound responsible is methyl anthranilate, first identified in grape juice in 1921, by Power and Chesnut. It is found in *labrusca*-type grapes but not in *vinifera*. Other compounds contribute—furanol, 2-aminoacetophenone—but methyl anthranilate is the signature.^b

^aThe sandwich became a childhood staple during the Depression, helped by sliced bread, which arrived in 1928, and cheaper peanut butter. The claim that it began with soldiers in the Second World War is folklore, though soldiers did eat it.

^bThe French have a word for the flavour: *foxé*, from *goût foxé*, the foxy taste, which comes from the English name for the species, the fox grape. Whether foxes eat the grape, or the grape smells like a fox, is a question I have not been able to resolve.

is a hybrid, with some *vinifera* in its ancestry.⁹

Bull wanted, in his own words, “a good table and wine grape, which shall also be early, hardy and prolific.” He got all three. The grapes then available in New England died in the winter or could not ripen before the first autumn frost. The European *vinifera* vines are not cold-hardy and are prone to disease in the eastern United States. The Concord ripened early and survived hard winters. It was exactly what was needed, and Bull gave it to the world, and the world took it.

Bull served in the Massachusetts legislature. He died in 1895 at the Concord Home for the Aged. He is buried in Sleepy Hollow Cemetery, and his epitaph reads, “He sowed, others reaped.”¹⁰

The man who reaped was a dentist. Thomas Bramwell Welch was born in Glastonbury, England, in 1825. He came to the United States, became a Methodist, became a prohibitionist, and settled in Vineland, New Jersey, where he practised dentistry and disapproved of alcohol. In 1869 he took forty pounds of Concord grapes—Welch’s says forty pounds—from in front of his house and pasteurized the juice, which kept it from fermenting, which kept it from becoming wine, which was the point. He wanted an unfermented grape juice for communion. The Lord’s Supper without the fermentation. He succeeded.

His son, Charles, turned the product into a business.¹¹ It is the jelly that I ate as a child in Iowa, on white bread, with peanut butter,

⁹Huber and others, in 2016, identified it as an offspring of ‘Catawba’ and an unknown wild parent.^a

¹⁰The words are widely quoted. The punctuation varies between sources. I have not seen the stone. I mean to.

¹¹In 1897 the business built a plant in Westfield, New York, on Lake Erie, in the heart of the Concord Grape Belt, a strip about sixty miles long through Chautauqua County. Welch’s sold Grapelade, a grape spread, from 1918, and grape jelly from 1923, and the jelly was made from Concord grapes, and it still is.

^aFew things are entirely what they seem. The most American of grapes is not entirely American.

in a kitchen I can see but cannot return to, in a town I will not name, because someone from there will write to correct me, and I would rather be uncorrected and free.

We honour the man who profits and forget the one who planted. This is not a thing I say with bitterness. It is a thing I say with interest, the way you might note which direction the wind is blowing without wishing it to change. Bull sowed. Welch reaped. The grape is indifferent to both of them.

The bunch is still on my desk. It is late January. Outside, the vines are dormant, and the pruning has not yet begun. In Napa the growers wait until February or March, because January rain carries fungal spores into fresh cuts, and a fresh cut on a vine is an invitation that should not be extended lightly. January is for marking the wood—deciding what stays and what goes, which is a kind of editing. You look at what grew last year. You decide what will be allowed to grow next year. You cut everything else. If you are too generous the vine makes too many clusters and none of them ripen well. If you are too severe you lose a year. The vine does not tell you which you have been. You find out in September.

I will count the grapes again in the morning. I expect a hundred and six.